

ASSESSMENT

An Honest Read

What I think you're building, what I'd bet on, what worries me, and what I'd do if it were mine. Written after a long session and meant to be argued with.

01

What it is

A Linux computer made simple.

That's the thing. Everything else — availability, verified reviews, the phone that answers, the remote control, the app store — is what it's *for*.

I drifted off that for most of today and framed it as a business platform with a box attached. That was wrong, and it matters, because the framing changes what you build first, what the demo is, and why the Linux stays visible.

The product is the computer. The apps are the reason to want one.

It's a category that has been empty for thirty years. Every previous attempt at simple Linux died on one of two things: an infinite hardware matrix, or no software people actually wanted. You solve the first by owning three SKUs and certifying them. You solve the second by shipping the free catalog people are already paying for, plus business software nobody else can build.

02

What I'd bet on

Ranked by how confident I am, not by revenue.

STRONG

Email as the universal API

The best single idea in the whole thing. Free, universal, unblockable, works for vendors that don't exist yet, and it's the acquisition mechanism for everything downstream. It also makes a free tier that needs no hardware, which collapses your CAC to near zero. I have not seen anyone else point this at small business.

STRONG

Churn absorption as the subscription

A correct read of what Red Hat actually sells, pointed at an upstream that moves far faster than kernels do. The shared flow library means the 401st Toast customer costs nothing — that's real operating leverage, and it's rare in a business with hardware in it.

STRONG

The incumbent analysis

Anti-correlation, not slowness. Toast can't say book direct. Google can't say own your data. FareHarbor is the commission. That's structural and it holds. The threat is a funded fast follower with no legacy revenue, not a big company.

STRONG

The buyer, and your ability to reach them

Small business is empty because CAC exceeds ACV and nobody technical can sell to a 58-year-old charter captain. Twenty years of door-to-door plus a schema that makes customer 400 cost the same as customer 20 is the combination that makes it work. This is the least replaceable thing you have.

GOOD

Remote control on the customer's own device

The technique is old; pointing it at small business on their own handset with their own SIM is a position nobody occupies. I'd bet on it *conditional on* the accessibility test, which is still unrun. That's the single largest unknown in the business.

GOOD

Verification as proof

Cheap to build, genuinely differentiating, and almost nobody does it. My only hesitation is that customers may not value it until the first time it saves them — it's

an insurance feature, and insurance sells poorly until there's been a fire.

GOOD**Real-time cross-channel availability**

Highest immediate ROI and the easiest sale — \$24K of commission is a number they can check. Hedged only because hospitality channel management is a crowded field and the execution details (email lag, walk-ins, reconciliation) are fiddlier than they look.

NOT YET**The App Store as an ecosystem**

Right long-term, and the Agent Plugins standard makes the format decision easy. But platform flywheels never bootstrap, and a developer needs a dense market before they build. This is a year-two thing that looks like a year-one thing, and building it early is one of the more expensive ways to feel productive.

NOT YET**Hardware**

The identity is a computer, so hardware has to happen. But inventory is a working-capital trap and you can prove every claim with software on their hardware first. Twelve months minimum before a container of anything.

03

The kiosk

You raised the wall-mount form factor. It's the right first shape, and it's the cheapest hardware decision you can make.

Bring your own screen

The box plugs into a display they already own — a TV in the back office, a monitor at the front desk. No panel in your BOM, no cracked-screen RMAs, no display supply chain, lower shipping weight and cost. Bundle a touchscreen later as a premium option once you know people want it.

What "kiosk" actually requires

- **One app, fullscreen, no exit.** cage — a Wayland compositor that runs exactly one application. There is no desktop to fall out of, no taskbar, no file manager, nothing to accidentally close.
- **Survives a power cut.** Auto-login, auto-start, back on screen in under a minute with no keyboard. This is the thing that separates a product from a demo.
- **A physical recovery button.** Hold five seconds → reflash the factory image, keep their data. Solves 40% of support calls before they're made.
- **Readable across a room.** Ten-foot layout, eight tiles, no menus. Norigin Spatial Navigation for D-pad and remote.
- **Charge-limited phone cradle.** Duty-cycle USB power — 80% then cut, drift to 60%, charge again. A handset pinned at 100% swells, and a swollen battery in a customer's back office is a story you don't want.

Three details that bite in a real business

- **Glare and mounting height.** A back office has fluorescent lights and a window. Matte panel, and mount at eye level for a standing adult, not seated.
- **Heat.** A Strix Halo box behind a wall-mounted screen in a Gulf Coast kitchen corridor is a thermal problem. Fanless is quiet and throttles; fanned is louder and survives. Test in August, not January.
- **Cables.** Power, HDMI, USB to the phone, ethernet. Four cables on a wall looks like a science project. Solve it in the mount or they'll put it in a drawer.

THE POINT The kiosk is where "a Linux computer made simple" stops being a claim. Someone walks past it and sees a screen showing their business. If that screen is ever a Linux desktop, an error dialog, or a login prompt, the product has failed in front of everyone who works there.

What worries me

Ranked by how likely they are to be what actually goes wrong.

1 Nothing is running

This is the one. Today produced four documents and zero evidence. The plan is now refined well past the point of diminishing returns — more architecture does not increase your odds, and I don't think anything else I write does either.

The pattern matters more than the day: fourteen years of seeing this clearly and not shipping it. Planning is satisfying and building isn't, and you now have a stack of artifacts that *feel* like progress. They're scaffolding. The thirty-second video of a real business's hours changing is progress.

2 Scope, still

Nine deployable units, 112+ repos, four businesses, fourteen verticals, a computer, an app store, a payment rail, a directory, a hardware line and a referral network. Every one of those is a company. I've raised this several times and it hasn't moved, which tells me it's load-bearing for how you think rather than an oversight — so I'll say it once more plainly and then stop: **the architecture can be broad, the next ninety days cannot.**

3 You're solo, and the spec assumes a team

Phases A through C alone are roughly six months of full-time engineering. You're not doing that while also selling, filming, recruiting and raising. Either the timeline is 3× longer than it looks, or you hire before you think you need to. Probably both.

And I'd hire **one engineer before a CTO**. A CTO is a strategic bet you can't easily undo; an engineer who can ship Phase A is the thing you actually need in January.

4 The accessibility test is still unrun

Every layer below the business model rests on it. It costs one phone and one afternoon, and it has been outstanding for the entire session. The fact that it hasn't happened yet is itself a signal worth paying attention to.

5 Speed, against someone with no conflicts

You can be right about everything and lose to a funded team that reads the same market and starts six months ahead of you on execution. Your defenses — flow library, verified data, installed base, payment volume — all compound *after* you ship and none of them exist yet. Being early is only an advantage if it converts.

6 Hardware working capital

You pay the ODM 90 days before customers pay you. Many hardware companies die solvent on paper. This is fully solvable by not touching hardware for a year, which is what I'd do.

05

What I'd do if it were mine

Not what's optimal in theory. What I'd actually do, knowing it's one person with a sales background and limited runway.

1. **Run the phone test this weekend.** One afternoon. It either unlocks Phase E or it changes the shape of the company, and either answer is worth having on Monday.
2. **Build the free tier only.** Email forward in, canonical record with provenance, live availability page out. Eight to ten weeks. No box, no phone, no app store, no directory.
3. **Sell twenty of them.** One vertical — vacation rental managers or charter fleets, because the ticket size is high and twenty customers is real volume. Gulf Coast only. Charge from day one; free pilots teach you nothing.
4. **Then add the second thing customers ask for**, not the second thing on the roadmap. Let them pick.
5. **Hire one engineer** around customer ten, when you have revenue and you know exactly what's breaking.
6. **Hardware at month twelve**, to customers who already pay you and have asked for it.
7. **App Store in year two**, when a developer can look at your installed base and see a market.

CUT Everything else for now — the directory, points, referrals, the model catalog, voice, the smart home node, the other twelve verticals. None of them are wrong. All of them are year two or later, and each one you touch now costs you a month you don't have.

06

The honest odds

What I think actually happens, weighted:

Never ships	most likely	Not because it's wrong. Because the planning never stops and there's always one more thing to get right first. This is the outcome to fight.
Ships small, works	good chance	A hundred businesses, \$600K–1M a year, a real company that pays you well and that you own outright. Most founders would take this and most don't get it.
Ships and compounds	real but narrow	The flywheel catches — agencies, chambers, payment volume, the directory. \$5–20M. Requires shipping in the next six months and hiring well.
The big version	unlikely, not absurd	Infrastructure for local business truth, the thing AI assistants query. Needs everything to go right plus timing plus capital. Worth building toward; wrong to plan around.

The distance between row one and row two is not talent, capital, architecture or insight. You have all four. It's whether a specific afternoon happens this month.

07

The one thing

You are not short an idea, a plan, a stack, or a market read.

You are short one running thing.

Everything I'd want to know next about this business — is the remote control viable, will an owner pay \$499, does the email parse survive real mail, is the availability number correct enough to publish, will a bookkeeper refer you — none of it can be answered by thinking harder. All of it is answered by one node, one business, one week.

The documents from today are good and I'd use them. But they're a map, and you've been drawing it for fourteen years. The territory is a phone, a laptop, and a restaurant on 30A that will let you plug something in.

60 Pick the business. Run the test. Film it.

Written as an assessment, not a recommendation to follow blindly — you know this market and this buyer better than I do, and where we disagree the burden is on me, not you. Companions: the Playbook, the Build Spec, the Build Plan, the Parts Catalog.